

GLOBAL INTELLIGENCE SUMMARY

Weekly Delta: * **Twitch:** Confirmed release of new engagement features (Watch Streaks, Clip Leaderboards) and enhanced chat moderation tools on July 17, 2026, indicating a continued focus on community stickiness and creator control. * **YouTube Live:** Playables Builder, an AI-powered custom game creation tool, remains in closed beta as of early 2026, signaling ongoing development in interactive content. No new general releases detected in the immediate past week, but the platform's major 2025/2026 updates (Dual-Format Streaming, React Live, AI Highlights, Practice Mode, Playables) are now widely deployed.

Trend Summary: 1. **Convergence of Short-Form & Long-Form:** Both Twitch and YouTube are aggressively integrating live streaming with short-form video. Twitch is enhancing clip tools for virality and multi-format support, while YouTube's Dual-Format streaming pushes vertical live content directly into the Shorts feed, complemented by AI-powered Shorts creation from VODs. This is a strategic imperative to capture and retain audiences across all content formats, leveraging the virality of short-form for live discoverability. 2. **AI as a Creator Co-Pilot:** AI is increasingly deployed to reduce creator burden and enhance content quality and discoverability. YouTube's AI highlights, AI-generated comments in Practice Mode, and the Playables Builder exemplify this. Twitch's automated clip identification also falls into this category. This signals a shift towards AI-assisted content creation, moderation, and engagement. 3. **Interactive & Gamified Engagement:** Platforms are pushing for deeper viewer participation through gamified and interactive features. Twitch's Custom Power-ups, Watch Streaks, and Clip Leaderboards, alongside YouTube's Playables and React Live, aim to increase watch time, foster community stickiness, and drive monetization through virtual goods and shared experiences. 4. **Creator Empowerment & Monetization Diversification:** Platforms are expanding monetization avenues (Twitch opening subs/Bits to all, Creator Dashboard sponsorships) and providing better analytics/tooling (Twitch's analytics overhaul, YouTube's Practice Mode) to attract, retain, and empower creators to build sustainable careers. 5. **Multi-Format & Cross-Platform Reach:** YouTube's Dual-Format streaming is a significant strategic move, allowing creators to reach audiences on any device and across different content feeds without duplicating effort. This addresses the fragmented consumption habits of modern audiences.

Competitive Foresight: What competitors might copy next: 1. **YouTube's Dual-Format Streaming:** The ability to simulcast horizontal and vertical streams with a unified chat, and push vertical live content directly to a short-form feed (like Shorts), is a powerful discoverability and reach tool. Twitch, Kick, and Facebook Gaming will likely need to develop similar capabilities to avoid being outmaneuvered in mobile-first viewership and comprehensive short-form content integration. 2. **YouTube's AI-Powered Live Highlights (Auto-Shorts):** The automation of short-form content creation from long-form streams is a massive time-saver for creators and a potent discoverability engine. Competitors will seek to replicate this AI-driven efficiency to help their creators generate more viral content and extend content lifecycle. 3. **YouTube's Playables / Playables Builder:** Interactive minigames and AI-powered custom game creation offer a unique

layer of engagement. This could become a differentiator for platforms seeking to move beyond passive viewing into truly interactive entertainment. Twitch, with its Extension ecosystem, is well-positioned to integrate similar concepts, but YouTube's AI-driven builder is a significant step ahead. 4. **Twitch's Watch Streaks & Custom Power-ups:** These are effective gamification mechanics for retention and monetization. Competitors will look for similar ways to incentivize consistent viewership and drive real-time, Bit-like interactions. 5. **Twitch's Creator Dashboard Sponsorships:** Direct integration of sponsorship opportunities within the platform reduces friction for creators to monetize beyond platform revenue share. Other platforms will likely follow suit to empower their creators with more diverse income streams.

PLATFORM-WISE BREAKDOWN

TWITCH

Feature Name: Monetization for All Creators (Subscriptions & Bits)

- **Category:** Monetization Intelligence
- **Description:** Twitch has opened up eligibility for subscriptions and Bits (virtual currency) to streamers of all sizes, removing previous barriers for smaller channels.
- **Strategic Intent:** To democratize monetization, incentivize a broader base of creators to stay and grow on Twitch, and increase overall platform revenue by expanding the pool of monetizing channels.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Higher creator retention across all tiers, increased content diversity, and a potential uplift in overall platform revenue through a larger, more engaged creator ecosystem.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Feb 2025, rolled out in 2025)

Feature Name: Advanced Clip Discovery & Editing Tools

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence, Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution
- **Description:** Introduced new tools for automated identification of clip-worthy moments during streams, smoother in-platform editing, and expanded sharing options. Includes support for 2K video and vertical video extraction from dual-format streams for clips.
- **Strategic Intent:** To enhance content virality, capitalize on the short-form video trend, improve creator workflow for content repurposing, and increase discoverability of VODs and clips across and off-platform.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Increased engagement with short-form content, higher off-platform traffic driven back to Twitch, and improved creator satisfaction and efficiency in content creation.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Feb 2025, rolled out in 2025; Create Clip From VOD in open beta Dec 2025)

Feature Name: Creator Dashboard Sponsorship Opportunities

- **Category:** Monetization Intelligence
- **Description:** The Creator Dashboard now directly connects creators with sponsorship opportunities, streamlining the process for securing brand deals.
- **Strategic Intent:** To provide direct, diversified monetization avenues for creators beyond platform revenue shares, strengthen creator loyalty, and position Twitch as a comprehensive platform for creator business.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Increased creator income, stronger creator-platform relationships, and potentially more brand-integrated content on Twitch.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Flagged by CCO in Feb 2025, implying active deployment)

Feature Name: New Interactive Features with Bits (Custom Power-ups)

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence, Monetization Intelligence
- **Description:** Launched "Custom Power-ups" and plans for other interactive features that rally community support using Bits, designed to gamify specific moments within a stream, similar to Hype Trains.
- **Strategic Intent:** To drive real-time viewer interaction and participation, increase Bit consumption, and enhance community stickiness through dynamic, shared experiences.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** More dynamic and engaging live streams, increased Bit revenue, and stronger community bonds through active participation.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Custom Power-ups launched Oct 2025; other features implied for future)

Feature Name: Watch Streaks

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** A new engagement feature that rewards viewers for consecutive watch sessions on a specific channel.
- **Strategic Intent:** To increase daily and regular viewership, foster habit formation among viewers, and boost overall watch time on the platform.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Higher average watch time per viewer, improved viewer retention, and more consistent audience presence for creators.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (July 17, 2026)

Feature Name: Clip Leaderboards

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** Introduced leaderboards showcasing top clips or top clip creators, gamifying the creation and sharing of short-form content.

- **Strategic Intent:** To incentivize the creation and sharing of viral content, provide a new avenue for clip and creator discoverability, and foster competitive engagement within the community.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Increased volume and quality of clips, enhanced discoverability for creators, and a new layer of community interaction.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (July 17, 2026)

Feature Name: Enhanced Chat Moderation Tools

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution
- **Description:** General updates and expansions to chat moderation functions, providing creators with more robust tools to manage their communities effectively.
- **Strategic Intent:** To improve community safety and reduce toxicity, provide creators with better control over their chat environments, and ensure a more welcoming experience for all users.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Safer and more positive chat interactions, reduced burden on creators for moderation, and improved platform reputation.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (July 17, 2026)

Feature Name: Conduits (Developer API)

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution
- **Description:** Generally available EventSub transport method for developers, designed to improve scalability and reliability for third-party integrations.
- **Strategic Intent:** To empower developers to build more robust and stable applications, improve the overall Twitch ecosystem, and ensure better performance for integrated tools.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** More stable and feature-rich third-party applications, leading to a richer and more integrated streaming experience for creators and viewers.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Jan 25, 2024 - foundational tech, still relevant for ecosystem)

Feature Name: Creator Analytics Dashboard Overhaul

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution
- **Description:** Redesigned and expanded the Creator Dashboard analytics, separating three insights pages into six (Achievements, Discovery, Earnings, Engagement, Overview, Stream Summary) with improved data presentation and guidance.
- **Strategic Intent:** To empower creators with deeper, more actionable insights into their performance, help them understand audience behavior, identify growth opportunities, and optimize content and monetization strategies.

- **Impact Hypothesis:** More data-driven decision-making by creators, leading to optimized content strategies, improved channel growth, and better monetization outcomes.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Rolling out by end of Dec 2025)

YOUTUBE LIVE

Feature Name: Dual-Format Streaming (Horizontal + Vertical Simulcast)

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution, Competitive & Strategic Intelligence, Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** Creators can now broadcast live in both horizontal and vertical formats simultaneously from a single stream, with a unified chat experience. Vertical live streams are also prominently featured in the YouTube Shorts feed.
- **Strategic Intent:** To maximize creator reach across all devices (desktop, TV, mobile) and content feeds (main feed, Shorts feed), cater to diverse viewing preferences, directly compete with TikTok Live and Twitch for mobile-first audiences, and simplify creator workflow.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Significantly increased discoverability and viewership for live content, stronger community cohesion across different viewing formats, and a competitive edge in the multi-format streaming landscape.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Made on YouTube 2025, rolled out 2025/2026)

Feature Name: React Live

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence, Competitive & Strategic Intelligence
- **Description:** A new feature allowing creators to start a vertical livestream on mobile and react in real-time to other live events or creators' streams.
- **Strategic Intent:** To leverage the highly popular reaction content format, drive co-watching and shared viewing experiences, foster creator collaboration, and directly compete with TikTok's duet/stitch features and Twitch's co-streaming.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Introduction of new, highly engaging content formats, increased viewer interaction and shared experiences, and potential for viral moments and cross-promotion.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Made on YouTube 2025, building on successful pilot)

Feature Name: AI-Powered Highlights (Auto-Shorts)

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution, Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** AI automatically identifies compelling moments from livestreams and generates ready-to-share Shorts, which can be saved privately or made public for the

Shorts feed.

- **Strategic Intent:** To reduce post-production burden for creators, significantly increase the output of short-form content, drive discoverability for live streamers through the high-reach Shorts feed, and extend the lifecycle of live content.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Greater volume of high-quality Shorts, accelerated channel growth for live streamers, and improved discoverability leading to increased live viewership.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Made on YouTube 2025)

Feature Name: Practice Mode

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution, Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** A private rehearsal mode allowing creators to test their setup, practice responding to chat (with AI-generated comments), and get comfortable before going live to the public.
- **Strategic Intent:** To lower the barrier to entry for new live streamers, reduce performance anxiety, improve the quality of initial broadcasts, and encourage a broader range of creators to experiment with live content.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Increased number of new live streamers, higher quality and more confident initial broadcasts, and a smoother onboarding experience for live content creation.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Made on YouTube 2025)

Feature Name: Playables on Live (Minigames)

- **Category:** Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** Integration of over 75 "lightweight" (casual) games directly into live streams, allowing creators and audiences to play together.
- **Strategic Intent:** To significantly increase viewer engagement and interaction, provide new and diverse content formats, differentiate the YouTube Live experience, and potentially open new monetization avenues through in-game purchases or sponsorships.
- **Impact Hypothesis:** Higher chat participation, longer average watch times, enhanced community stickiness, and a more interactive and entertaining live viewing experience.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Feature Release (Announced Made on YouTube 2025, "can now be played")

Feature Name: Playables Builder (AI-powered Custom Games)

- **Category:** Streaming Infrastructure & Tech Evolution, Engagement & Retention Intelligence
- **Description:** A tool utilizing Google's Gemini AI to enable creators to build custom, playable games for their streams using text, image, or video prompts.
- **Strategic Intent:** To empower creators with unique, highly personalized interactive content, leverage advanced AI capabilities for content generation, and deepen platform lock-in for interactive live experiences.

- **Impact Hypothesis:** Creation of highly innovative and engaging interactive streams, increased creator loyalty due to exclusive tooling, and a significant differentiator in the interactive live streaming space.
- **Status Tag:** ■ Experiment/Beta (Early 2026, closed beta, limited regions)

KICK

- No new intelligence signals detected for this reporting period.

FACEBOOK GAMING

- No new intelligence signals detected for this reporting period.

OTHERS

- No new intelligence signals detected for this reporting period.